

Week 9

Monday, 21 September 2026 3:08 pm

Week 4 — UI/UX Prototyping, Wireframing & Usability

Courses:

- UI/UX Design Fundamentals (LinkedIn Learning, or an equivalent course)
- UX Foundations: Prototyping and Wireframing (Figma / Adobe XD)
 - Figma or Balsamiq Essential Training (pick a wireframing tool)
- User Experience (UX) for Non-Designers or Product Managers
- Design Thinking: Understanding the Customer Journey

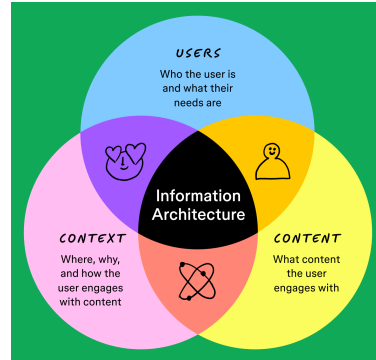
Key Concepts:

- Information architecture,
- low-fidelity wireframes vs. high-fidelity prototypes,
- heuristic evaluation,
- component hierarchy,
- accessibility standards (WCAG).

Information Architecture (IA)

What it is: The visual and conceptual structural blueprint of a app or website. It determines how content is grouped, labeled, and linked so users can intuit where they are and where to go next.

- **Key Focus:** Navigation design, search taxonomies, site maps, and content grouping.
- **Real-World Example:** On an e-commerce website like Amazon, IA is what organizes millions of items into logical categories (e.g., *Electronics > Computers > Laptops*), creates the global search bar, and dictates the checkout flow sequence.



Low-Fidelity Wireframes vs. High-Fidelity Prototypes

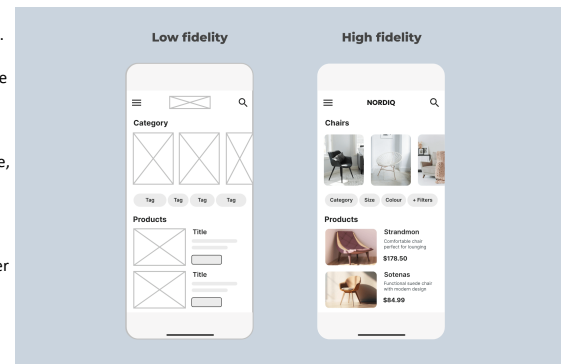
What it is: Two distinct stages of visualizing and testing a product's interface as it evolves from concept to launch.

Low-Fidelity Wireframes:

- **Details:** Simple black-and-white layouts, block diagrams, or paper sketches. They intentionally exclude colors, fonts, images, and brand polish.
- **Purpose:** To quickly map out layout, content placement, and user flow without getting bogged down by visual aesthetics.
- **Example:** Sketching three rectangular boxes on a whiteboard to decide where the header, hero image, and call-to-action button should go on a landing page.

High-Fidelity Prototypes:

- **Details:** Pixel-perfect, fully styled interactive models built in tools like Figma or Axure. They feature actual brand colors, micro-animations, clickable buttons, and dynamic data.
- **Purpose:** To simulate the real product experience for user testing, developer handoff, and stakeholder approval.
- **Example:** A clickable mobile app preview where tapping "Add to Cart" triggers a sliding drawer animation and updates the cart counter badge in real time.

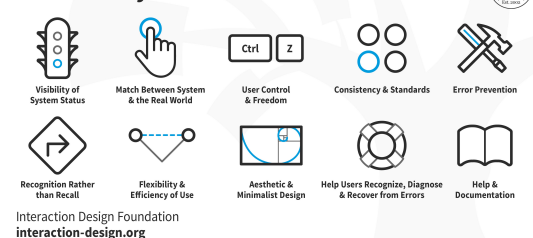


Heuristic Evaluation

What it is: A systematic usability inspection where UX experts evaluate an interface against a set of recognized usability principles (heuristics), most commonly Jakob Nielsen's 10 Usability Heuristics.

- **Key Focus:** Identifying friction points, missing feedback, or confusing navigation before public testing.
- **Real-World Example:** Evaluating a food delivery app against the *Visibility of System Status* heuristic. If a user places an order and the app doesn't show a loading indicator or confirmation screen, it fails the heuristic because the user is left wondering if the transaction went through.

10 Usability Heuristics



Interaction Design Foundation
interaction-design.org

Component Hierarchy

What it is: The structured, nested organization of UI elements, inspired by systems like Atomic Design. Smaller, foundational elements build up to form larger, complex components and full pages.

- **Key Focus:** Scalability, design system organization, and UI consistency across teams.
- **Real-World Example:**
 - **Atoms (Base):** An icon, a text label, and a background container.
 - **Molecules (Combined):** Combining the text label and container into a standalone **Button**.
 - **Organisms (Complex UI):** Combining multiple buttons, text fields, and images to form a **Navigation Header** or a **Product Card**.

Component Hierarchy consisting of four levels:

- Screens** – Main entry points or pages within a module. A module can have one or multiple screens depending on navigation and layout differences.
- Features** – Larger functional sections within a screen that are typically composed of multiple components and may require their own internal structure.
- Components** – Small, reusable UI elements such as buttons, inputs, dropdowns, forms, or modals.
- Shared** – Common elements used across multiple modules or screens, such as headers, layouts, design system elements, and reusable components.

Accessibility Standards (WCAG)

What it is: The Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG)—a internationally recognized set of standards designed to ensure digital products are usable for everyone, including people with visual, auditory, motor, or cognitive disabilities.

- **Key Principles (POUR):** Perceivable, Operable, Understandable, and Robust.

- **Real-World Example:**
 - **Color Contrast:** Ensuring dark text on a light background meets a minimum 4.5:1 contrast ratio so visually impaired users can read it.
 - **Screen Readers:** Adding descriptive alt text (alt="Blue denim jacket on a hanger") to product images so blind users using screen reader software understand what is on screen.
 - **Keyboard Navigation:** Ensuring every interactive element (like a form field) can be navigated using only the Tab key for users who cannot use a mouse.
- <https://www.accessibility.org.au/guides/what-is-the-wcag-standard/>
- **Practice:**
 - Take your Week 1 feature ("reorder past meal") and design a clickable, 4-screen interactive wireframe/prototype in Figma.

<https://www.figma.com/make/AYuSWcBJJilSvXKTdsoKWZ/My-Vodafone-Mobile-App-Prototype?t=RmErwPct8mgpkwvy-1>
 - Run a 10-minute usability test with a peer, log friction points, and document 3 revised UI/UX requirements.